DEBATE PREPARATION

Technology vs. Sustainable Living

Which is more effective at combating climate change?

POSITION: PRO-TECHNOLOGY Your side argues that TECHNOLOGY is the primary solution

SCALE	SPEED	RESULTS
PILLAR 1	**PILLAR 2**	**PILLAR 3**
Industrial systems need tech transformation	Tech spreads faster than behaviour change	Already reducing emissions today

THE 3 PILLARS — ARGUMENT TREE

TECHNOLOGY IS THE PRIMARY SOLUTION TO CLIMATE CHANGE

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PILLAR 1: SCALE

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- 36 billion tons CO_2/yr
- Coal plants
- Steel production
- Transport systems
- Requires system overhaul

PILLAR 2: SPEED

v

- Solar: -90% cost since 2010
- Cheapest electricity in history
- India and China solar farms
- EVs spreading globally
- Faster than any campaign

PILLAR 3: REAL WORLD

v

- Electric Vehicles (Tesla)
- Wind energy (Denmark)
- Carbon removal (Climeworks)
- Modern agriculture (FAO)
- Feeding 8 billion people

v

Technology changes the **SYSTEMS** — Sustainable living only changes **HABITS**

THE THREE PILLARS — IN DEPTH

PILLAR 1 — SCALE

Climate change operates at a scale that individual lifestyle choices cannot match. Every year the world emits around 36 billion tons of CO_2 — produced not by individuals, but by the industrial architecture of the modern world. Only transforming that architecture can move the needle.

Coal Plants	Burning coal is the largest source of CO_2. No lifestyle campaign replaces a coal plant — only cleaner technology does.
Steel & Cement	These industries emit enormous CO_2 by their very chemistry. Decarbonising them requires breakthrough technology, not consumer choices.
Transportation	Global freight, aviation, and shipping cannot be fixed by lifestyle change. Electric propulsion and green hydrogen are the only real solutions.

KEY DEBATE LINE

"Climate change is a problem created by large industrial systems, so it must be solved by transforming those systems through technological innovation."

PILLAR 2 — SPEED

Technology adoption is exponential. Once a breakthrough becomes cost-competitive, it scales globally within years. Behavioural change requires shifting the habits of billions of people — progress is slow, inconsistent, and reversible.

Solar Energy	Solar costs dropped ~90% since 2010 — now the cheapest electricity in history. India and China built massive solar farms in years, not decades.
Wind Energy	Denmark now generates a huge share of its electricity from wind turbines — a transformation driven by deployment speed, not public campaigns.
Mass Adoption	One technological shift in the energy sector reduces emissions faster than decades of individual lifestyle campaigns.

KEY DEBATE LINE

"Technological solutions spread much faster than changes in human behaviour."

PILLAR 3 — REAL-WORLD SUCCESS

The strongest case for technology is not hypothetical — it is the track record it has already built. Multiple technologies are actively reducing emissions at scale today.

Electric Vehicles	Tesla and the EV revolution pushed every major automaker to invest heavily in electric transport — a system-level shift driven by competition.
Carbon Removal	Climeworks and others are deploying direct air capture plants that physically remove CO_2 from the atmosphere. No lifestyle change does this.
Modern Agriculture	The FAO credits technology with feeding 8 billion people. Local organic farming alone could not meet global food demand.

KEY DEBATE LINE

"These technologies are not theoretical — they are already transforming the global energy system."

ARGUMENT LINES — MEMORISE THESE

Five core arguments. Learn them cold — each is a self-contained weapon.

1

SCALE ARGUMENT

"Climate change is a problem created by large industrial systems, so it must be solved by transforming those systems through technological innovation."

2

SPEED ARGUMENT

"Technological solutions spread much faster than changes in human behaviour."

3

REAL-WORLD SUCCESS

"These technologies are not theoretical — they are already transforming the global energy system."

4

HUMAN BEHAVIOUR ARGUMENT

"Technological innovation changes systems without relying on perfect human behaviour."

5

SYSTEM TRANSFORMATION

"Sustainable living changes personal habits, but technological innovation changes the systems that shape those habits."

KILLER WILDCARD EXAMPLE — AGRICULTURE

If the world relied only on sustainable living — local, organic farming — global food production would collapse. Modern agricultural technology is what feeds 8 billion people. Technology increases efficiency at a scale lifestyle change cannot reach. Use this to demolish romanticisation of individual behaviour change.

RAPID-FIRE DEBATE POINTS

Use these one-by-one to respond, attack, or pivot. Each one stands alone.

1 People won't stop travelling. Technology makes travel cleaner without requiring anyone to give up mobility.

2 Even if emissions stopped today, existing CO2 remains in the atmosphere. Only technology can physically remove it.

3 No lifestyle change alone could power an entire country. Technology can.

4 If sustainable living were enough, emissions would already be falling — but global emissions continue to rise.

5 Climate change is an industrial problem, not a personal one. Technology scales faster than behavioural change.

6 We cannot solve a problem created by industrial technology using only individual lifestyle choices — we must use better technology.

7 Technology gave us vaccines, renewable energy, and modern agriculture. The problem is not technology — it is which technology we choose.

8 Climate change was created by industrial systems. It must be solved by transforming those systems — not by asking individuals to shoulder the burden.

Good luck tomorrow. **The facts are on your side.** *Now make them feel it.*